which, despite the fanfare, changed none of the realities of the German and Berlin situations. Its strategic significance was negligible, though Moscow pledged to defend East German borders, meaning it didn't hand the GDR control of the important air and land access routes to West Berlin from the FRG, nor limit Western rights in West Berlin or the city's free political system. Unusually, the Soviets notified Washington and London in advance, assuring the treaty was not designed to spark a new international crisis. Typically, Ulbricht extolled the accord as 'an example of how socialist states can regulate their relations for the maximum benefit of both sides and at the same time for the benefit of international peace'.

During that trip to Moscow, Honecker could scarcely have missed increasing signs of disenchantment with Khrushchev, especially after the humiliating Cuban missile debacle. As many within the Russian Communist Party tired with their boisterous leader, a plot to oust him was hatched by Leonid Brezhnev, the 57-year-old president of the Supreme Soviet, along with the KGB and the military. After years of contact, Honecker enjoyed a friendly relationship with Brezhnev, a burly, bushy-browed, alpha male with the shoulders of a scrum-half (his eyebrows earned him the moniker 'brovenosets,' meaning 'brow cruiser'). He had wide experience in industry and agriculture, loved womanising, pigeon breeding, dominoes, cold-water swimming and most importantly, hunting. It remains unclear, though, if Erich was informed of the impending coup during this period.

In Berlin, meanwhile, Prime Minister Otto Grotewohl was gravely ill. His death in early September left Ulbricht as the surviving member of the triumvirate which founded East Germany. At Grotewohl's funeral, Honecker stood in the first guard of honour, alongside Kurt Hager, Alfred Neumann, Paul Verner and Erich Apel. The Berliner Zeitung was suitably poetic, reporting how:

coming straight from their jobs, women, men and young people paid their last respects to our late Prime Minister … Great is the sadness that moves them. But their determination to